The 2x2
How we made sense of what we heard

Health Promotion Board

aleph

The X-Axis — From Knowing to Doing

The x-axis maps how far health knowledge is being practised into action.

On the left: Know, Not Do. Youth can tell you what's healthy. They've heard the advice. But knowing doesn't change what they actually do — the easier choice still wins.

On the right: Know, And Do. Youth act on what they know not because someone is watching, but because they've built strategies that work for them.

Most youth aren't on the left because they don't care. They're there because no one has helped them **turn awareness into a practical routine that fits their real day.**

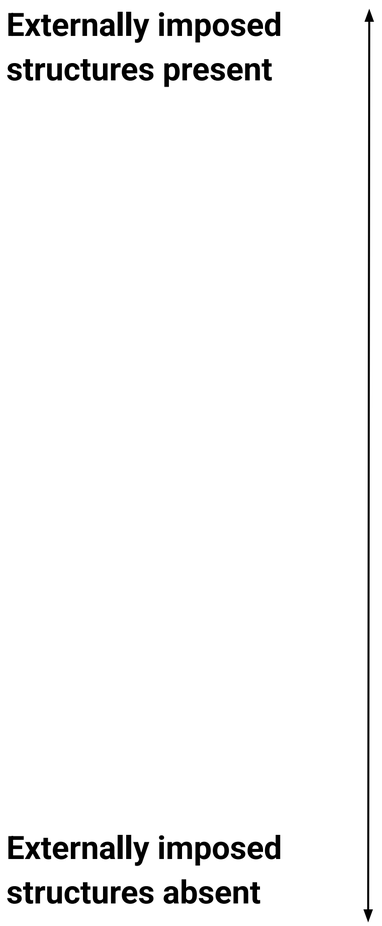
The Y-Axis — From Externally Imposed Structure Present to Externally Imposed Structure Absent

The y-axis maps whether someone is holding the routine in place.

At the top: **Externally imposed structure present.** Rules, routines, and adult supervision are active. In primary school, this is the default — parents, helpers, and Student Care Centres hold habits together.

At the bottom: **Externally exposed structure absent.** No one is enforcing, reminding, or watching. Youth are on their own. After-school hours, bedtime, and weekends live here.

The risk isn't that structure disappears, it has to. **The risk is that it disappears before youth have built the capability to replace it with their own.**



The 2x2 based on discovery and co-creation help us to organise what both phases were telling us

Youth and parents described the same patterns - drifting, resisting, giving up, bouncing back - but we needed a single map to see where youth get stuck and where they need to move.

Named where youth actually sit

The four quadrants named the patterns both sides described. It classified where youth actually sit - not where we assumed they were. These were mapped after discovery and co-creation findings.

Made the ‘vicious’ cycle visible

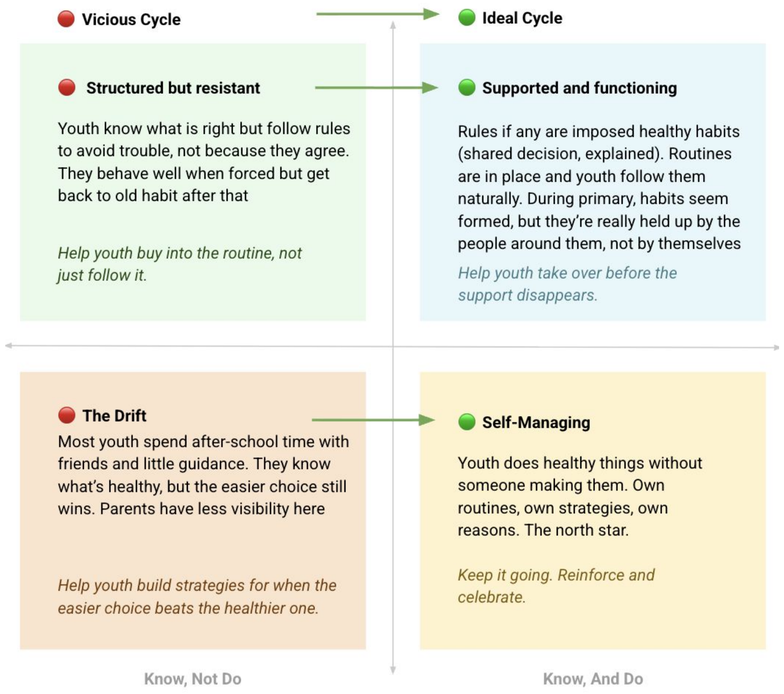
Youth bounce between drifting (no structure, easy choice wins) and resisting (structure imposed, youth pushes back). Both sides described this loop but had no way to see it as a pattern. The 2x2 made it visible as a cycle, not random behaviour.

Set the destination

Bottom-right is Self-managing - youth doing healthy things without someone making them. That became the north star. Every concept we designed is trying to move youth toward that quadrant before structure disappears completely.

Anchored every design decision

Each design principle resolves a specific quadrant problem - "autonomy with guardrails" addresses the top-left trap, "replace don't restrict" addresses why youth bounce between drift and resistance.



We want to move them from ‘Vicious’ to ‘Ideal’ cycle

X-AXIS

The X-axis maps how far health knowledge translates into action. From knowing but not doing on one end to knowing and doing on the other.

Y-AXIS

The Y-axis shows the presence of structure. From structure absent at the bottom to structure present at the top.

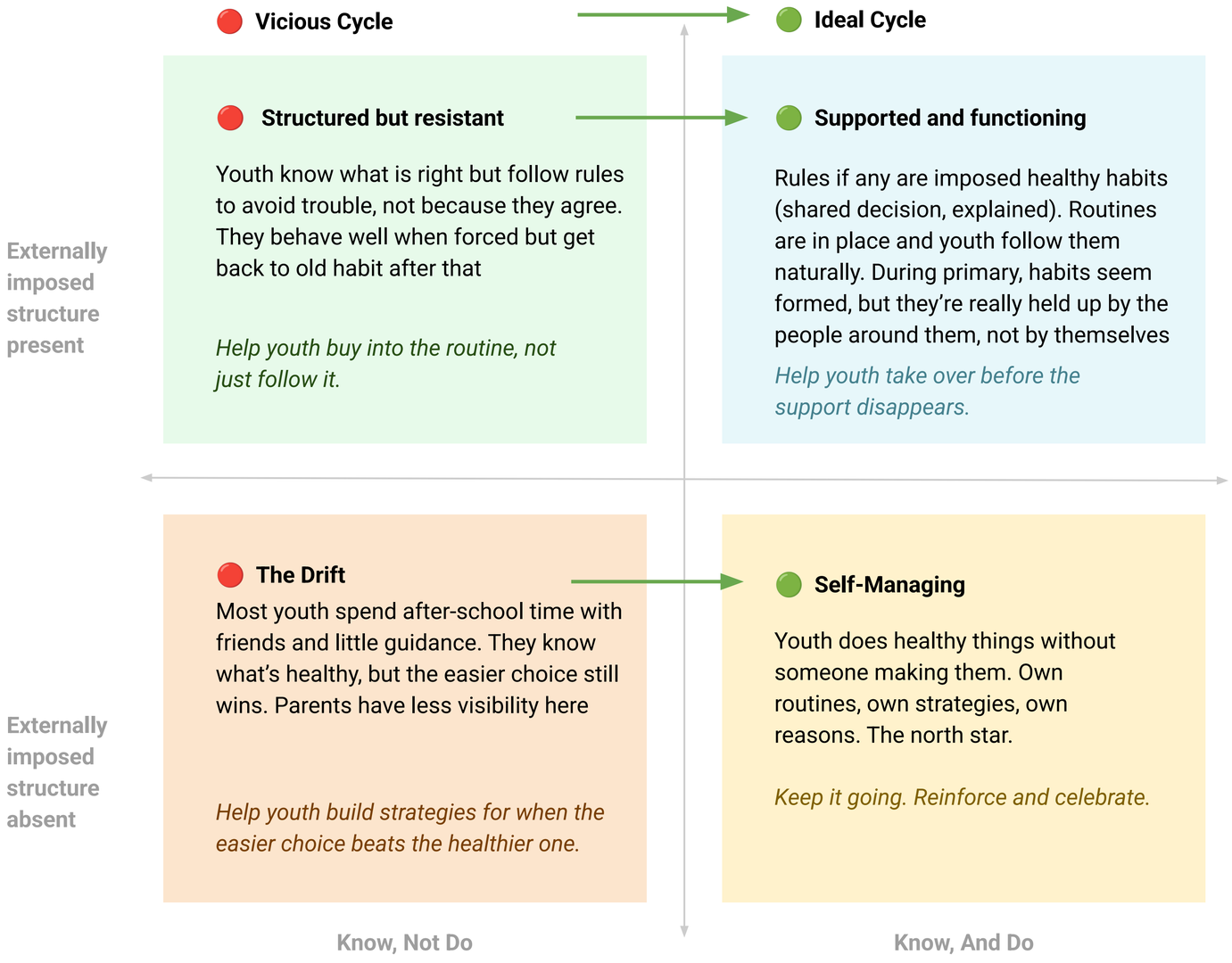
WHAT THIS HELPS US SEE

The current state is a vicious cycle: youth drifts, parent adds structure, youth resists, both get stuck. The desired state is a virtuous line: practical strategy, small win, growing confidence, less need for control.

FROM VICIOUS TO IDEAL

🔴 Vicious: Drift → Rules added → Youth pushes back → More rules or give up → Further drift. A loop.

🟢 Ideal: Practical strategy → Small win → Feels capable → Parent adjusts approach → Builds on it. A line.



Primary 6 → Secondary 1: The big handover

WHAT CHANGES

Student Care Centre ends (no more 2-7pm coverage). Helper's role reduces. Youth gets a phone and a house key. First time choosing what to eat with pocket money. After-school time shifts from adult-supervised to peer-led. Parents go from seeing most of the day to seeing very little of it.

THE DRIFT -> VICIOUS CYCLE

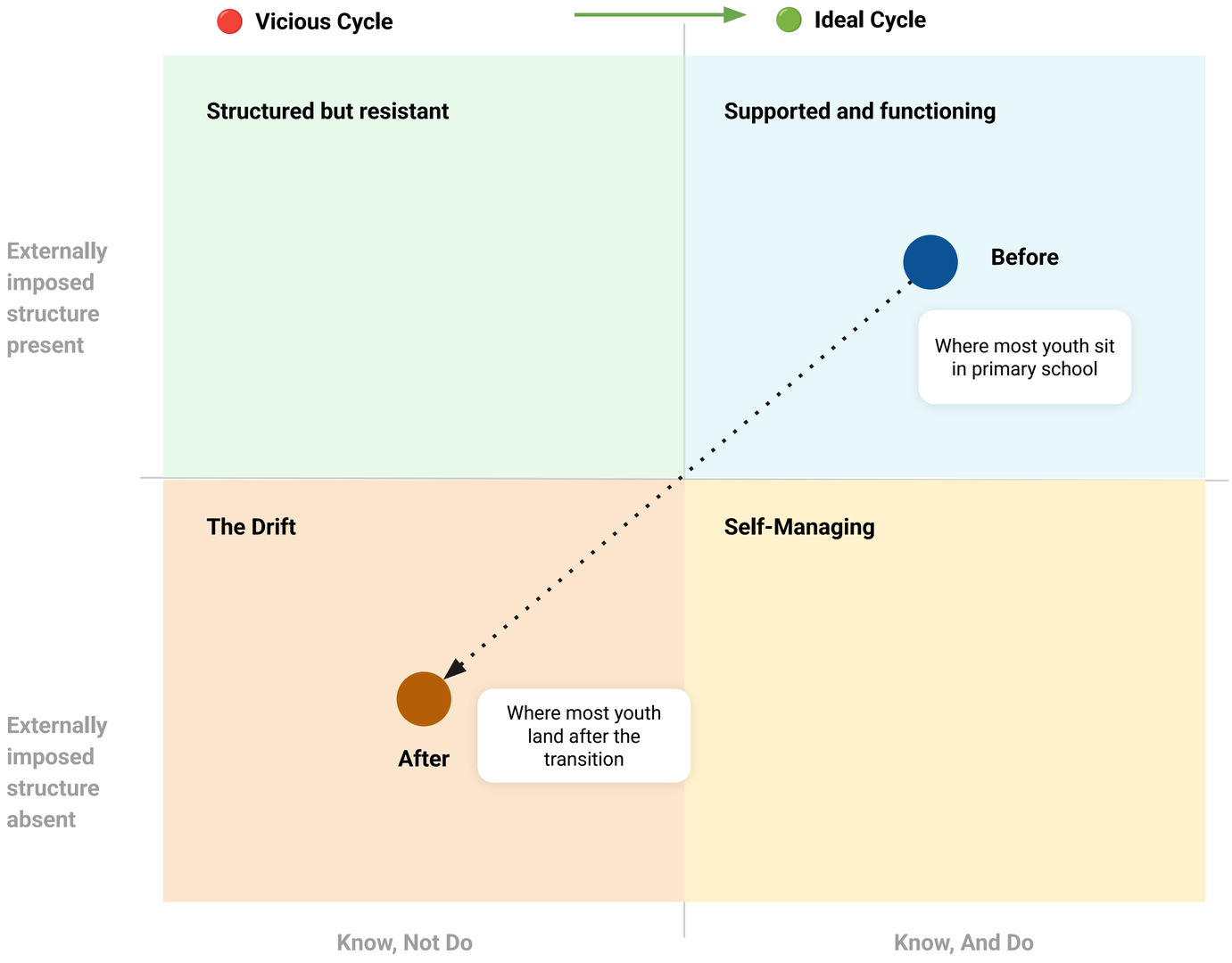
Youth starts drifting from the ideal cycle (sleeping later, eating McD with friends after school). Parent notices and reaches for the tools they know: take the phone, set a curfew. Youth pushes back or finds workarounds. One parent said his son ran away to a friend's house. Another's daughter used the helper's phone after pretending to sleep. The tools that worked for a 9-year-old do not work on a 13-year-old.

WHY THIS MATTERS FOR DESIGN

This is the best window to step in. The old routines haven't fully disappeared yet. Youth are still open to guidance, as long as it comes with explanation and feels fair. One parent said: "If this stage broken then very hard to counter in the future."

DESIGN IMPLICATION

Put new routines in place before the old support is completely gone. Concepts: self-set bedtime routines, trust conversations at Sec 1, phone-free dinner as an anchor ritual, gradual rules starting from dinner outward.



Secondary 2 → Secondary 3: The deepening drift

WHAT CHANGES

Peer influence becomes the stronger force. After-school time is fully shaped by friends. Fast food becomes a daily social ritual, not a food choice. Conversations with parents narrow to reminders: "did you eat," "go sleep," "stop your phone." Youth tunes them out. Both sides gradually stop talking about health altogether.

THE DRIFT -> VICIOUS CYCLE

Youth is stuck in the left half of the map, bouncing between the drift and structured but resistant. The cascade kicks in: screen time goes up, sleep goes down, eating suffers, exercise drops. 8 out of 11 youth and 5 out of 10 parents described this exact pattern. Parents either double down on rules (pushing youth into top-left) or give up entirely (leaving youth in bottom-left).

WHY THIS MATTERS FOR DESIGN

This is the leverage window. Habits haven't solidified into adult patterns yet. Youth are still malleable. But the intervention can't come through parents alone because that channel has narrowed. It has to come through peers, environment, and co-owned routines.

DESIGN IMPLICATION

Work through peer systems and environment redesign, not parental enforcement. Concepts: physical tiredness as sleep strategy, cold room for sleep, peer influence for fast food choices, group eating at hawker, board games at hangout spots.

Secondary 4 → JC / IHL: The fork

WHAT CHANGES

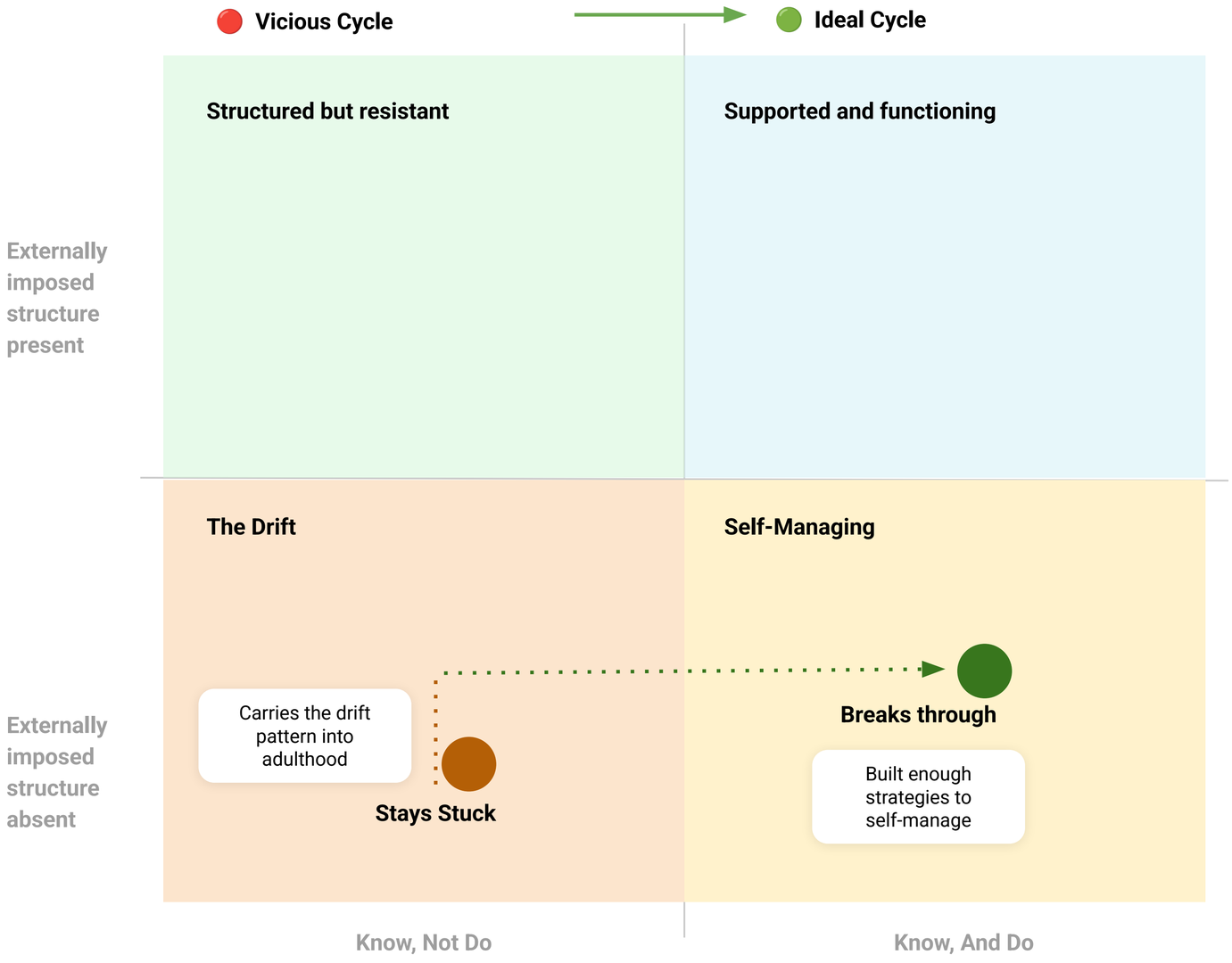
External structure has mostly stepped back. Youth is functionally self-governing. New environment (JC, Poly, ITE) resets social context. Peer group changes. Daily schedule changes. This is either the moment patterns from Sec 1-3 solidify into adult habits, or the fresh start where new routines take hold.

THE DRIFT -> VICIOUS CYCLE

Youth who built some self-management strategies during Sec 1-3 have something to carry into the new environment. They land bottom-right: self-managing. Youth who were stuck in the vicious cycle (drift ↔ resistant) carry those patterns forward. They land bottom-left: still drifting, but now with even less structure and no one watching.

WHY THIS MATTERS FOR DESIGN

This transition is outside our target scope (13-16), but it's the reason our intervention window matters. What we build for Sec 1-3 determines which path youth take at the fork. If they reach Sec 4 with practical strategies and self-management capability, the fork bends toward self-managing.

DESIGN IMPLICATION

Our concepts are not just solving for today. They are building the capability youth need to navigate the fork. Every self-set bedtime routine, every peer accountability system, every co-owned dinner ritual is an investment in the youth's ability to self-manage when they need their own routines to hold.